REVELATION

The Apocalypse of John

-The Four Views-

The Four Views

Historicist:
Revelation fulfilled throughout Church history

Preterist:
Revelation fulfilled shortly after time of writing

Futurist:
Revelation to be fulfilled in the future

Idealist:
Revelation has no single fulfilment but applies to all ages

Historicist

- Revelation fulfilled throughout history
- Survey of Church history
- E.g. – locusts=rise of Islam & conquest of Eastern Empire
- Rare today
- Wycliffe, Tyndale, Luther, Zwingli, Calvin, Knox
- Newton, Foxe, Wesley, Edwards, Whitfield
- Finney, Spurgeon, Henry & more!
- “The Protestant view”

Historicist

- "Year for a day" principle
  - 1 day in Revelation = 1 year in history
  - So 5 months = 150 years
- Taken from Ezekiel 4:4-6:
  - Lies on right/left side for 390/40 days
  - Represent years of judgment
  - "Prophetic time"
  - Apply mostly to Daniel & Revelation

Historicist

- Attempt to match history to John's vision
- A lot of conjecture
  - But some intriguing "successes"
- Focus on Papacy
  - Papal system is the anti-Christ
  - View grew out opposition to Pope's power
  - Argued by the Reformers

Historicist

- Accusation – “theological straightjacket”
  - Making Revelation partisan
- Their reply:
  - Other views “satanical distractions”
  - To obscure identity of anti-Christ
  - Preterism & Futurism invented by Jesuits

Historicist

- Remarkable link with Roman history
- Revelation & decline and fall of the Roman Empire
- Uncanny links between 5th & 6th trumpets – rise of Islam & Turkish invasion

Historicist

- Largest branch of Christianity run by the anti-Christ!
- No real agreement on interpretation
- History still going – where will it fit?
- Narrow focus:
  - Europe in the Middle Ages
  - Church in Asia/Africa/America?
- Relevance to first readers?

Preterist

- Revelation fulfilled in the past
- Argue pre 70 AD date
  - Focus on fall of Jerusalem
- Some differences in Preterism:
  - All Revelation about Jewish revolt
  - 1-19/20 about fall of Jerusalem
  - 1-11 – 70 AD, 12-19/22 – fall of Rome

Preterist

- Relevance to modern readers same as other prophetic books
- Similar to Isaiah, Jeremiah or Ezekiel
  - Most of it fulfilled
  - Elements of future promise
- Highly relevant to original readers
  - Revelation is a letter!
  - Therefore most relevant to O.R.
  - Though teaches other generations

Preterist

- “I am coming soon”:
  - Very soon – Jesus comes to judge Jerusalem
- Similarities between visions and Josephus

Preterist

- Olivet Discourse
  - “Little apocalypses”
  - Similar imagery & topic
- John no “little apocalypse”
  - Written “big apocalypse”
- Response to Temple question
  - About 70 AD (and a bit about 2nd Coming)
  - Revelation as well

Preterist

- Utter dependence on early date
  - If 90's approach falls apart
  - Ceases to be predictive
- Its origins:
  - Jesuit Luis de Alcazar (1554-1613 AD)
  - Catholic response to Historicism?

Preterist

- Eusebius (C4th AD):
  - Olivet = Fall of Jerusalem
- Andreas of Cappadocia (C6th AD):
  - Others hold to a Preterist view
  - "Those who apply… Jerusalem"
- Arethas (C6th or C9th AD)
  - "Shown… were to befall the Jews"
  - "Destruction… not yet inflicted by the Romans"

Futurist

- Revelation yet to be fulfilled
- Most common view
  - Dominates Christian media
  - Hal Lindsey, Tim La Haye
  - “The only view”

Futurist

- Dispensational:
  - C19th England
  - 7 “dispensations”
  - End of Church “dispensation”
  - Millennial “dispensation”
  - 2 peoples of God
  - Rapture & 2nd Coming separate

- Historical Pre-Millennialism:
  - Rapture & 2nd Coming the same
  - Church goes through Tribulation
  - Only 1 people of God – the Church

Futurist

- Book divided into 3 parts: (1:19)
  - "What you have seen"
    - Ch. 1 – Vision of Christ
  - "What is"
    - Ch. 2-3 – The Seven Churches
  - "What is to take place after this"
    - Ch. 4-22 – Tribulation/2nd Coming/Eternity

Futurist

- Interpret as literally as possible
- Events haven't happened yet
  - Don't have to be symbolic
  - Don't have to match visions with history
- A certain amount of symbolism
  - E.g. Millennium, anti-Christ's' rule, treaty with Israel, rebuilt Temple etc.
- Mix of literal & Symbolic
  - Lean towards the literal

Futurist

- Gives us a Divine snapshot of what will be – we want to know the future!
- Criticism of "newspaper exegesis":
  - Finding Revelation in today's events
  - Founding of Israel
  - China's military
  - Russians damming the Euphrates
  - We all think we're the last!

Futurist

- Suspicious roots:
  - Jesuit Francisco Ribeira (1585)
  - Developed to counter Historicism
  - Puts anti-Christ in the future – separates it from Papacy
  - View at first rejected by Protestants
  - Until Dispensational theology developed

Futurist

- Focus on prophecy, sometimes apocalypse
- Almost ignores the letter
- If future then ch. 4 onwards:
  - Irrelevant to original readers
  - Irrelevant to all readers (except last ones)
  - If rapture before tribulation – what has it do with the Church?
- Cannot be tested
  - everything in the future

Idealist

- AKA – spiritualist, non-literal, allegorical, symbolic, poetic
- Revelation not fulfilled in History
- Themes apply to all ages
- Visions understood symbolically
  - Applied to Church
  - Good vs. evil, Christ over Satan, vindication of the Martyrs, persecution of Christians…

Idealist

- Beast not specific person/nation/Empire
  - But any who oppose the Church
- Great Whore:
  - Compromised Church or seduction of the world
- Seals – disasters throughout history
  - God's sovereignty
- Principle not specific!

Idealist

- Doesn’t have to match with history
- Most believe will be a final beast, whore etc.
- Revelation applicable to all generations
  - Church always faces opposition
  - Gives hope their oppression will end
  - Jesus always wins!
  - Popular in persecuted Church

Idealist

- Seems to contradict:
  - Events Revelation says will take place
  - The prophetic side
- To combat – combined with other views
  - E.g. – take Roman elements of Preterist
  - Original readers – beast = Rome
  - Then picture applied to all "Romes" in history
- Often also follow dramatic structure/parallels

Idealist

- Goes against other apocalypses:
  - Beast in Daniel – Real Empires
  - Dragons in Esther – Real people
  - Oracles against Tyre & Babylon – Real cities
  - Olivet – Real destruction of Jerusalem
  - Why change the literature?
  - Principles instead of reality?

The Four Views

- Each has advantages & disadvantages
- Make up your own mind based on:
  - Observation & Interpretation
- Stay as inductive as you can
- Don’t have to choose just one
- “Pick ‘n mix” view is a very good option!